

I2 Hagar

The runaway servant who met the God who sees.

Hagar was an Egyptian servant in Sarai's household. She had no say in the biggest events of her life. Her mistress gave her to Abram to bear a child, then treated her so harshly that she ran away. Years later she was sent into the desert with her son and a single bottle of water. Yet Genesis gives Hagar something remarkable. She is the first person in Scripture to whom "the angel of the LORD" appears, and she gives the LORD a name: "Thou God seest me." Twice, when she was alone and in despair, God met her, promised a future for her son, and provided water in the wilderness. Her story reminds readers that God notices those whom others overlook.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hagar. Its meaning is uncertain
<i>Family</i>	Mother of Ishmael by Abram; she later found an Egyptian wife for her son (Genesis 16:15; 21:21)
<i>Background</i>	An Egyptian handmaid of Sarai (Genesis 16:1)
<i>Key places</i>	Abram's camp in Canaan; a spring on the way to Shur; the wilderness of Beersheba; the wilderness of Paran
<i>Key people</i>	Sarah, Abraham, Ishmael, the angel of the LORD
<i>Main passages</i>	Genesis 16:1–16; 21:8–21
<i>New Testament</i>	Galatians 4:21–31, where the KJV spells her name "Agar"

"And she called the name of the LORD that spake unto her, Thou God seest me: for she said, Have I also here looked after him that seeth me?"

Genesis 16:13, KJV

The life of Hagar

Genesis gives no dates for Hagar. Ages below are Abraham's, taken from Genesis 16:16 and 21:5.

Abram age 85	●	Given to Abram After ten years in Canaan without a child, Sarai gives Hagar to Abram "to be his wife." Hagar conceives and begins to look down on her mistress. <i>Genesis 16:1-4</i>
Soon after	●	Runs away Sarai deals harshly with her, and Hagar flees into the wilderness. By a spring on the way to Shur, the angel of the LORD finds her, tells her to return, and promises countless descendants. <i>Genesis 16:5-12</i>
At the well	●	Names the God who sees Hagar calls the LORD "Thou God seest me." The well is named Beer-lahai-roi. <i>Genesis 16:13-14</i>
Abram age 86	●	Bears Ishmael Hagar returns and bears Abram a son. He is named Ishmael, "God shall hear," as the angel said. <i>Genesis 16:15-16</i>
At Isaac's weaning	●	Sent away Sarah sees Ishmael mocking and demands that Hagar and her son be cast out. Abraham gives Hagar bread and a bottle of water and sends them away. <i>Genesis 21:8-14</i>
In the wilderness of Beersheba	●	Rescued again The water runs out. Hagar sets the boy under a shrub and weeps. God hears the lad, opens her eyes to a well, and promises to make him a great nation. <i>Genesis 21:15-21</i>

Key activities

Genesis 21:14 has puzzled readers. Ishmael was probably a teenager by then, yet the verse seems to picture Hagar carrying "the child." Many think the verse means she carried the bread and water on her shoulder while the boy walked with her.

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- 1 Bore a child for another woman.** She was given to Abram as a second wife so that Sarai might "obtain children by her." *Genesis 16:2-4*
 - 2 Despised her mistress.** Once pregnant, she looked down on Sarai, and the household fell into conflict. *Genesis 16:4-5*
 - 3 Fled and was found.** She ran from harsh treatment, and the angel of the LORD met her by a spring. *Genesis 16:6-8*
 - 4 Returned and submitted.** At the angel's word she went back to Sarai, carrying a promise for her unborn son. *Genesis 16:9-12*
 - 5 Named God.** She called him "Thou God seest me," the God who had seen her misery. *Genesis 16:13*
 - 6 Wept in the desert.** Sent away, she could not bear to watch her son die, and she cried aloud. *Genesis 21:14-16*
 - 7 Saw the well.** God opened her eyes, and she filled the bottle and gave the boy a drink. *Genesis 21:17-19*
 - 8 Raised her son.** She lived with Ishmael in the wilderness of Paran and found him a wife from Egypt. *Genesis 21:20-21*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Hagar.

Old Testament

Genesis 16:1–16; 21:8–21	The two accounts of her story
Genesis 25:12	Ishmael's line begins with "Hagar the Egyptian"
1 Chronicles 5:10; Psalm 83:6	"Hagarites," often linked to her, though unstated
Echo: Exodus 3:7	God sees and hears the afflicted

New Testament

Galatians 4:21–31	"Agar" as an allegory of the covenant from Sinai
Echo: John 4:5–14	Jesus offers living water to a woman at a well
Echo: Luke 12:6–7	God knows even the sparrows

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What questions did the angel ask Hagar at the spring (Genesis 16:8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the angel sent Hagar back to Sarai instead of simply rescuing her?
3. *Apply:* Hagar learned that God saw her. When have you felt unseen, and how does her story speak to that?
4. *Apply:* Who in your church or neighborhood might feel overlooked, and how could you see them this week?